

“Before the Lawyer” - The Interrogation Game

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The Interrogation Game is a narrative-driven, time-bound detective experience, focused on extracting a confession through strategic questioning. The game begins with a one-time case narration, creating immediate cognitive load and requiring careful attention. The player then enters an interrogation interface consisting of a case file, live suspect feed, timer with logs, and an interactive murder board.

The **core loop** is structured as:

analyse evidence → select a question → observe suspect response → update logs → build pressure → evaluate readiness → trigger “Get Confession.”

Each evidence presents three question types - correct, ambiguous, and misleading - where only correct selections contribute to progress (later refined based on feedback).

Rules:

- The narration is **non-repeatable**
- A confession is only unlocked if **≥70% correct questions** are selected
- Incorrect or misleading questions:
 - Waste time
 - Reduce interrogation effectiveness
- The player must act within a strict **time limit (refined from 15 to 5 minutes)**
- Hints are limited and **cost time (30 seconds each) (refined from 30 to 15 seconds)**
- The final action, “**Get Confession,**” is a **risk trigger**:
 - Success only if the threshold is met
 - Failure results in the suspect walking free

The system is designed to create **controlled uncertainty and psychological pressure**. **Key mechanics** include an **evidence-based questioning system**, a **hidden progression model**, **time-bound gameplay**, and a **final risk trigger**. A **progression bar was initially included but removed during iteration** to avoid over-guidance and increase tension. The suspect’s responses evolve based on **questioning quality, reinforcing feedback without explicit indicators**. The experience aligns with the **MDA framework**: *Mechanics* - time limit, scoring threshold, interrogation flow, *Dynamics* - rushed, instinct-driven decisions, and *Aesthetics* - tension and the feeling of being a pressured, slightly reckless detective.

Although the system is logically binary, subtle phrasing differences create a **stochastic perception**, making choices feel uncertain and engaging. The core rule - **the player cannot win without proving competence** - ensures that progression is earned, not guessed.

Design Iterations & Refinements

- **Initial Direction - Detective Game with Backgrounds:** Early concepts included detailed environmental backgrounds. This was later simplified to prioritise focus on interrogation and reduce cognitive overload.
- **Ambiguous Question Element:** The ambiguous option created confusion during testing. It was refined to ensure clearer distinction between meaningful and misleading choices.
- **Time Optimisation:** Gameplay duration was reduced from **15 minutes to 5 minutes** to better align with user attention span and enhance intensity.
- **Narrative Structure (Prequel Issue):** Early versions felt incomplete, like a prequel. The narrative was restructured to deliver a more self-contained and engaging experience.
- **Narrative Depth Enhancement:** Additional layers were added to improve immersion, clarity, and emotional engagement.
- **Removal of Progression Bar:** The visible progress indicator was removed to increase uncertainty and prevent over-guidance.
- **Feedback Loop Adjustment (Positive & Negative):** A dynamic time-based system was introduced:
 - Correct evidence + question → **+5 seconds** (reward)
 - Incorrect choices → **-15 seconds** time loss (penalty)This reinforces both positive and negative feedback loops, influencing player behavior.

The design process began with research on narrative and decision-based games such as *Papers Please*, and *Ace Attorney*, followed by ideation across multiple concepts including a trade-based system and a Darbar-style negotiation game. The interrogation format was selected for its clarity and intensity. Initial system design defined the rules, flow, and mechanics, which were translated into a **Figma prototype (single flow)**. User testing revealed **key gaps: incomplete narrative context, excessive duration, unclear target audience, reliance on the progression bar, confusing ambiguous options, and weak onboarding**. Based on this feedback, critical refinements were implemented - **time reduced to 5 minutes, progression bar removed, onboarding repositioned, ambiguous option removed, narrative strengthened, and audience clearly defined**. The final prototype was developed on **Antigravity and VS Code**, integrating all iterations into a cohesive and intuitive system. The resulting experience centers on “**High-Risk Interrogation Trigger**” - a moment where the player must decide when to act, balancing logic, pressure, and uncertainty, knowing that acting too early or too late leads to failure.